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What is a Gender-Sensitive Budget and Brazil's challenges in adopting it

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Abstract

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This note discusses the concept of Gender-Responsive Budgeting (GRB), presenting three international experiences (Australia, South Africa, and Ecuador) and two Brazilian municipal experiences. In the Brazilian case, in addition to a brief presentation of the experiences of Recife and Belo Horizonte with the implementation of a GRB, the discussion focuses on the budget structure, the way the federal budget is prepared, its rules, and its limitations. Although focused on the federal budget, state and municipal budgets largely follow a similar logic, so that the limitations and difficulties observed at the federal level can be replicated in other federal entities. Based on the experiences investigated, it is argued that, although the preparation of a national budget often prioritizes macroeconomic criteria such as the solvency of public debt, which can be seen as a neutral process and free of any privileges or biases, it is necessary to understand how its components can contribute to the reproduction or reduction of structural inequalities. We understand that the budget must act in a representative way in promoting a national project and in the search for greater cohesion and a fairer society. A gender-responsive budget seeks to evaluate all public policies in terms of their impacts on gender inequalities, and to value and promote successful public policies in this context. Considering international advances and recommendations on gender-responsive initiatives, we seek to understand Brazil's current stage in this context and the challenges the country faces in implementing a gender-responsive budget.

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1. Introduction

The size and allocation of public budgets are topics of debate worldwide. Budgets include social programs and pensions, direct and indirect taxes, investment and development promotion policies, and the provision of public services such as education and health care, among others. Each of these structures and policies is built around one (or more) objectives, which can lead to disputes within the budget. Decisions on the public budget can be made for several purposes, such as reducing inequalities or maintaining economic activity, with anti-cyclical policies to avoid or reduce the magnitude of crises.

In Brazil, we have seen discussions about the budget and the rules for determining spending and collection being discussed and modified, especially in view of the tax reform and the adoption of a New Fiscal Framework - the Sustainable Fiscal Regime (SFR). The SFR, for example, assigns rules to the growth of public spending and investment linked to the need to balance public accounts, focusing on ensuring a primary surplus in most scenarios, but also including a countercyclical mechanism (Brenck et al., 2023). This, however, is not the only possible criterion for allocating a budget. In fact, as criticized by the literature (Marques et al., 2023; Brenck et al., 2023), such a rule ends up exacerbating existing budget disputes, compressing space for discretionary expenses, on the one hand, and raising the debate on the revision of the constitutional floors of health and education, on the other.

In this context, this note presents an alternative to the allocation of budgetary resources: Gender-Sensitive Budgets (GSB). The GSB seeks to evaluate all public policies and budget elements for their impacts on gender inequalities, using this criterion as a guide for building the budget and its components. Although the gender inequality agenda has advanced on several fronts, GSB is not widely adopted across countries. In this sense, based on international and municipal experiences, we discussed the challenges of adopting a GSB in Brazil.

This policy note is organized into four more sections in addition to this introductory one. In the next section, we present the concept of Gender-Responsive Budgeting, its emergence, purpose and requirements for implementation. In the third section, we discuss three experiences of implementing gender-sensitive budgets, one in Australia, South Africa and, finally, one in Ecuador. In the section that follows, we address the Brazilian case and discuss two municipal experiences: Recife and Belo Horizonte. In the final considerations, we briefly discuss the structure of the Brazilian budget and the main challenges to implementing a gender-sensitive budget at the federal level.

2. Budget Structure and the Gender-Sensitive Budget

a. The Brazilian budget structure

The budget is the instrument for achieving a government's objectives. It is through it that resources are allocated and implemented in government actions, enabling the government to achieve its real objectives (Hofbauer, 2012). The legal structure of the Brazilian public budget is defined by the Federal Constitution of 1988 (CF/88), in its articles 165 to 169. However, the conceptual and methodological basis of this structure, guided by the program-budget, has its origins in the General Budget Law (Law no. 4.320/1964), which revolutionizes the meaning of public budget in Brazil. From that moment on, the integration between planning and budget is materialized from the instrumentalization of "programs", that is, a set of government actions oriented to a certain objective.

The Brazilian budget system is built through the Pluriannual Plan (PPA), the Budget Guidelines Law (BGL), and the Annual Budget Law (ABL). According to Rodrigues (2020), the Pluriannual Plan represents an ordinary law prepared every four years, whose beginning and end do not coincide with changes in presidential terms. In this way, continuity in budget planning is guaranteed in favor of State policies rather than the specific policies of each government. Meanwhile, the Budgetary Guidelines Law is also an ordinary law, which defines the economic and fiscal parameters (such as primary result targets) and the most important works and services to be carried out in the following year, in addition to listing other expected expenses, such as increases in civil servants' salaries, the appreciation of the minimum wage and transfers to States and Municipalities, as well as legislative tax changes. As Rodrigues (2020) argues, the Annual Budget Law aims to ensure compliance with the goals and actions proposed in the PPA, in accordance with the guidelines and goals established by the BGL, and must be forwarded to the legislative branch for discussion by August 31 each year. All expenditure made by any public agency must be provided for in the ABL. The ABL comprises the Fiscal Budget, Investment Budget, and Social Security Budget, covering all entities and bodies linked to the Federal Government, whether in direct or indirect administration, in addition to the funds and foundations established and maintained by the government.[1]

b. What is a Gender-Sensitive Budget?

A gender-sensitive budget (GSB) - also known as “responsive budgeting”, “results-based budgeting” or “focused budgeting” - is an economic approach to public budgeting that considers the differential impacts of government spending and taxation on women relative to men - and possibly also includes a perspective that gives visibility to ethnic and racial minorities, and other marginalized groups. This approach seeks to increase focus on minority groups,

[1] State and municipal governments follow this same perspective, and therefore, the analyses can serve as a basis for changes in budgets at all three levels of government.

propose changes to the objectives that guide the public budget, and examine the resulting impacts. Thus, we seek to ensure that public policies can correct inequalities based on gender, race, and ethnicity and promote equality.

The first experiences with sensitive budgets that shed light on their impacts on a minority group were gender-focused budgets, officially instituted from the Fourth United Nations World Conference on Women and the 1995 Beijing Platform for Action. At this time, we sought to make commitments with a view to greater gender equality and strengthening women's rights (Reis, 2014). However, to understand what a focused budget is about, it is necessary to step back and examine how public policies that represent expenses from a budgetary perspective are classified. In general, public policies aimed at reducing inequalities tend to have a universal character, allocating public resources to all citizens without distinction (Costa; Osório; Silva, 2006). Once some lack of access by certain groups is found, affirmative policies are created as strategies to expand the universal aspect of public policies through the prioritization of discriminated groups (Costa; Osório; Silva, 2006). Focused policies, in turn, are defined as those in which it is argued that the State chooses partial strategies, allocating a certain level of resources to the poorest and excluded layers of the population (Costa; Osório; Silva, 2006).

When writing about the implementation of gender-sensitive budgets, Elson (2005) explained that the establishment of a GSB should include planning across different government departments. Technical studies need to consider policies covered by the budget and the potential scope of each project in a transversal way, that is, including more than one secretariat or ministry. The results will also depend on the areas in which these strategies have been implemented, as policies may have different goals. Elson (2005) exemplifies this logic by discussing a policy to reduce inequality between boys and girls through education spending. Such a strategy requires changes not only in the Ministry of Education but also in several other government programs and wings, including entities and agencies that provide social assistance to families. The author also clarifies that the objective of a gender-responsive budget initiative is not to produce a parallel budget focused on women, but rather to analyze, in general, the existing public policies from a gender perspective, identifying their impacts and potential differences between men and women. It is also worth noting that the gender assessment in the budget can be structured to allow the inclusion of other configurations, such as class, race, or religion.

The transversality of these inequalities needs to be consistently incorporated into government ministries, secretariats, and agendas, extending across the political sphere. Since we have already started from unequal points within the current social structure, the responsiveness of this theme concerns not only one face of public management but all governmental instances. This is what exemplifies Hofbauer (2003), who addresses how reproductive health spending tends to focus on women's responsibility for fertility control rather than a shared responsibility between men and women. The author adds that the effects of a public health policy that controls the female body can be detrimental to the scope of women's rights and to the construction of new social positions that allow equality between genders.

To avoid these and other problems, gender-sensitive budgeting should also pay special attention to the training and instruction of women so that they can critically reflect on their interests and formulate strategies to make them work in the public sphere, in line with their various realities. The participation of minority groups - sometimes removed from the public debate – is essential to achieve results in policies that seek to achieve equity within a structurally unequal society.

3. Experiences around the world: Australia, South Africa, and Ecuador

The thesis that a gender-focused budget could reduce inequalities and significantly improve the situation of women has been defended by several researchers - such as Elson (2005) and Hofbauer (2012). A gender-sensitive budgeting process must include gender mainstreaming in the formulation and evaluation of policies, as well as in each aspect of spending. That is, from the perspective of minority groups, the budget is prepared so that resources are directed towards equity. According to Jácome and Villela (2012), Australia was the pioneer in applying a gender-sensitive budget. The work began in 1984, and for 12 years, the government assessed the impacts of the budget on the reality of Australian women.

Jácome and Villela (2012) point out that the Australian experience began earlier, in the mid-1970s, through the so-called Office of the Status of Women (OSW) located in the main policy coordination body: within the Prime Minister's department. The OSW was composed of feminists - also called femocrats, in reference to their role in favor of democracy - recruited to identify and analyze the gender impacts in all proposals that reached the stage of submission to the Cabinet (Jácome; Villela, 2012). The work of the femocrats, in conjunction with OSW's strategic position, played a key role in creating the gender-sensitive budget.

The authors also emphasize the importance of the new budget for changing the thinking of Australian public servants. Many of them had never reflected on the differentiated impact that policies could have on men and women. Even the economic team believed its policies affected the population equally, without considering gender distinctions. The program continued with the objective of conducting annual audits of the budgets (from the municipal to the federal level) for each department, to assess whether there has been an evolution in the government's goals regarding girls and women. However, after 1996, the Australian initiative lost momentum. According to Sanches et al. (2021), one of the reasons for the weakening of the initiative was the fact that it was created entirely at the

initiative of the government, without great involvement of civil society, which resulted in the lack of social pressure to maintain it - especially in view of the exchange of governments.

In 1995, South Africa took a step forward towards equity through sensitive budgets (Sanches et al., 2021). The country's experience differs from Ecuadorian and Australian experiences in the origins of the efforts, stemming from the union of civil society and newly elected women in parliament, who took advantage of a moment when hope in South African politics was growing. Jácome and Villela (2012) explain that, during the initial three years of drafting the gender-sensitive budget proposal, the budgets of the 27 local government departments were analyzed, which resulted in a new methodology, even more complex than the Australian one, composed of:

> (i) examine the position of girls, boys, women and men in each sector, by disaggregating information by sex, age, ethnicity and geographic location;
>
> (ii) review industry policies to assess whether the situation is being handled in a gender-sensitive manner;
>
> (iii) analyze the resources destined to instrument the policy;
>
> (iv) define indicators to assess whether resources are being used effectively to achieve planned objectives.
>
> (Jácome and Villela, 2012)

The knowledge developed by researchers in South Africa broadened the scope of gender-sensitive budgeting methodology to include disaggregated information not only by sex but also by ethnicity, age, and geographic location.

The country's experience led to breakthroughs over the following years, including the Gender Mainstreaming and Sensitive Budgeting guideline package in 2005. The draft Law on Women's Empowerment and Gender Equality (WEGE), adopted by the National Assembly in 2014, sought to increase women's participation in positions of power in both the private and public spheres. In 2019, the Gender-Sensitive Planning, Budgeting, Monitoring, Evaluation and Auditing Framework (GRPBMEAF) was approved. The framework consists of a structure for implementing several theoretical and legal advances within the scope of the sensitive budget, including granting the National Treasury the power to take actions in this area. He expected its implementation in the government to be effective in the same year; however, there were delays. Gender inequality remains at high levels in South Africa, but efforts towards a GSB have continued. In 2021, the National Treasury began collaborating with FMI's Regional Technical Assistance Centre for Southern Africa (AFRITAC South) and the Department of Tax Affairs to apply a GSB, based on guidance developed in an IMF-funded project to design a GSB guide, focused on South Africa, in 2017[2].

Finally, the experience of building the GSB in Ecuador is interesting because it begins in a context of economic instability, reduced state action, and the strengthening of neoliberal policies. Seeking to survive the profound social effects of the crisis, Ecuadorian women organized strategically, ensuring that families and communities could withstand the dramatic drop in wages and public services (Reis, 2014). The collective organization of Ecuadorian women in neighborhoods and communities gave rise to women's movements that later shaped Ecuador's political landscape. The popular struggle movement enabled governments pursuing policies to confront the neoliberal crisis to be elected, following the Latin American “pink tide”. Reis (2014) discusses how the women's movement in Ecuador, during this period, achieved important results through its presence in the economic discussions of the 2007 Constituent Assembly. The country changed the structure of the General Budget and included gender equality as a budgetary function, equating it with fundamental obligations such as health and education (Reis 2014). An example of the advances achieved by Ecuador in its experience with GSB was the recognition of care work as productive work, as well as the inclusion of the obligation for the State to provide policies, programs, and resources to promote gender equality.

The Ecuadorian experience also resulted in the preparation of the Equal Opportunities Plan for Ecuadorian Women (EOP 2005-2009). In addition to the diagnosis of each area addressed by the plan, issues related to economic rights and access to financial and non-financial resources, as well as the impact of structural adjustment policies on women's lives, were also incorporated (CONAMU, 2005). Ecuador achieved significant results in gender policies, as the Ecuadorian organization facilitated the approval of more than 20 laws aimed at reducing gender inequalities between 1995 and 2000. Among the legislations are the Law of Political Quotas (1997), the Law against Violence against Women (1995), and the National Plan for Sexual and Reproductive Health (2007) (Reis, 2014). In the areas of health and education, a reduction in female mortality from violent causes and an increase in the proportion of women with higher education were observed (Castro; Guerrero, 2018).

The changes in how Ecuador views the public budget were reflected in the new Constitution of 2008, which, for example, included Article 289, which defined the Ecuadorian economic system as a social and solidarity approach in which the human being is both subject and end (Castro; Guerrero, 2018). The Ecuadorian experience has combined several elements that define it as a successful GSB experience, including popular engagement, structural changes in the country's public policies, technical monitoring, and practical economic applications. In addition, the initiative was cited by the World Economic Forum (WEF) in 2023 as an exemplary example of integrating a more comprehensive gender dimension into classifiers that included environmental and equality policies (Zrinski; Seiwald, 2023). Even today, Ecuador continues to advance gender equality through its budget. An example is

[2] To learn more about the project, see: https://blog-pfm.imf.org/en/pfmblog/2021/10/advancing-gender-responsive-budgeting-in-south-africa

the Violet Economy Act[3], aimed at promoting equal employment and treatment between men and women, including with regard to family-related leave[4]. The law, enacted on January 20, 2023, only came into force on January 20, 2024[5].

4. Responsive budgeting in Brazil: experiences and challenges

In recent years, Brazil has witnessed a significant reduction in inequality, driven by increased budgetary resources for social spending (Marques et al., 2022). Although a budget reconfiguration can improve welfare systems and reduce class inequalities, it does not always advance gender equity (Reis, 2014). Building greater gender equity implies a redistribution of power and resources between men and women. Thus, such equity involves not only redistributing income and guaranteeing rights, but also deconstructing stereotypes that have historically been maintained and reinforced certain social roles, such as the imposition of responsibility for reproductive work on women (Reis, 2014).

Although there is no concrete national experience, records indicate several actions aimed at developing tools to support the establishment of a gender-sensitive budget in Brazil since the 2000s. One of them was conducted through a non-governmental organization and with some government sectors that pressed for transparency in data availability, since, at that time, identifying spending directed to women was not a trivial task (Xavier; Rodrigues, 2022). Thus, in 2002, the Women's Budget (WB) was developed by the Feminist Center for Studies and Advisory (FCSA), which aimed to monitor the implementation of policies with a direct or indirect impact on women's lives, as well as to incorporate their demands into public planning. The construction of the WB was based on monitoring gender issues through budget instruments such as the PPA and the ABL. The creation of the Women's Budget represented an important step not only in mapping gender-impact policies but also in advancing greater transparency in federal public spending.

Also in 2003, the creation of the Special Secretariat for Policies for Women (SSPM), which materialized the National Plan for Policies for Women (NPPW), also symbolized advances towards equal opportunities within the budget. In 2005, with the support of the women's caucus in Congress, WB was the first thematic budget to be included as a permanent consultation by the government (Vieira et al., 2014). The articulations of the early 20s meant that, in 2005, Brazil became the first country to enable daily monitoring of the application of public resources aimed at protecting women (MOP, 2022; Xavier; Rodrigues, 2022). However, many of these initiatives were discontinued after 2015, among them the Women's Budget.

It is important to emphasize that the Women's Budget was part of an important struggle to transform the Brazilian budget into a more transparent, democratic, and participatory process (Xavier; Rodrigues, 2022). In addition, WB allowed advancing the institutionalization of the gender perspective within government planning. However, because it was not definitively institutionalized in the Constitution, the advances were gradually lost in subsequent political cycles (Xavier; Rodrigues, 2022). Thus, Xavier and Rodrigues (2022) emphasize that the implementation of a GSB also depends on the political context in which the initiative is embedded, since both the current political and economic projects can either suppress or strengthen the opportunity.

In 2020, the women's caucus in the Chamber of Deputies rescued the idea of the Women's Budget through another initiative. At this point, two articles are included in the draft Budgetary Guidelines Law (BGL) for 2021, requiring the executive branch to develop a methodology that would identify gender-sensitive expenses and publish them in a report. The report "The Woman in the Budget" is then created. However, the report itself takes a critical perspective and points out the difficulties in the low visibility of programs with an impact on women, due to the lack of transparency in government actions (Santos, 2022). Facts that reinforce the point that, although the country has a structure to discuss the issue of women in the budget, elements for the effective implementation of a GSB are still missing.

Over the past two decades, the country has advanced legislatively through the enactment of laws such as the Maria da Penha Law in 2006, the Law to Encourage Female Participation in Politics, and the Femicide Law, both enacted in 2015. However, these movements were not organized around the teachings arising from the construction of a GSB. The Maria da Penha Law was the result of years of fighting against violence and pressure from international organizations[6]. The Femicide Law in Brazil establishes the criteria for framing a homicide crime as a murder motivated by structural gender inequality, when committed against women because they are women. The adoption of this legislation in Brazil followed the trend of other Latin American countries, which had already changed their legislation in this regard previously[7]. Faced with the drastic increase in the number of cases of femicide, in 2012, the National Congress implemented a Joint Commission of Inquiry to assess the level of violence

[3] This law was created in partnership with the Economic Forum and the Inter-American Development Bank (IDB) within a specific GSB program. See: https://www.weforum.org/impact/gender-gap-accelerators-benefits-over-850000-women/

[4] https://www.weforum.org/videos/ecuador-gender-equality-violet-economy-law/

[5] https://www.weforum.org/impact/gender-gap-accelerators-benefits-over-850000-women/

[6] The Brazilian State only made a serious commitment against domestic violence after being convicted of omission and negligence by the Inter-American Court of Human Rights in the case of Maria da Penha.

[7] https://agenciabrasil.ebc.com.br/direitos-humanos/noticia/2018-11/brasil-concentrou-40-dos-feminicidios-na-america-latina-em-2017

against women in the country, resulting in the bill launched in 2013, undergoing some changes until it was sanctioned by then-President Dilma Rousseff in 2015 (Campos, 2015).

The Law on Female Participation in Politics, on the other hand, is part of an old struggle, since the country has adopted quotas for women's candidacies since 1997, establishing at least 30% and at most 70% vacancies for each sex on the party lists. However, the lack of visibility and incentive for female candidates made it necessary to legislate on the use of campaigns for female candidates and on advertising aimed at promoting female participation in politics[8]. Even with the incentives, political parties have not complied with the requirement to transfer funds to campaigns under gender and race quotas[9]. Female participation in the political sphere is essential to enable the construction of a budget that reflects the reality of Brazilian women, in addition to strengthening political debate and democracy.

Despite efforts and advances in mapping public spending through the Women's Budget, it cannot be said that the country has actually implemented a gender-sensitive budget at the national level, as in the countries mentioned above. The discontinuation of these initiatives after a few years and the very lack of articulation of several of these policies around an explicit GSB proposal caused the country to move slowly towards greater structural changes in the budget.

With this in mind, it is interesting to discuss two Brazilian cities that sought to apply gender-responsive budgets in their municipal planning. Recife was the pioneer city in implementing a GSB, a project that began in the PPA from 2001 to 2004 and whose experience was presented at Mercosur international meetings and recognized by the UN. The city of Recife succeeded in engaging the population through dialogue, resulting in proposals for public policies for women that began in the 2001-2004 Multiannual Plan and continued for several years. Most of the proposals were suggested by civil society through the municipality's participation channels (Pereira, 2018). At that time, the itinerant daycare project was invested in, so that mothers had someone to leave their children with while discussing the municipal budget. Among the policies discussed were the fight against violence against women, social control, women's participation in municipal education network public policies, and the coordination of actions to reduce women's poverty (Adrião, 2019).

In this context, the Women's Coordination was founded in 2001 and, later, in 2010, they created the Special Secretariat for Women (Adrião, 2019). The city has made advances in the scope of assistance and prevention of domestic violence, and in reproductive and sexual health through investments in humanization programs for childbirth and ensuring follow-up for pregnant women. In 2002, the Clarice Lispector Reference Center was inaugurated to welcome women in situations of domestic and sexual violence. Since then, the institution, which remains active to this day, has a staff of psychologists, social workers, lawyers, and social educators, among others, and offers support and guidance to victims of violence (Adrião, 2019). By 2019, it was estimated that more than 3,000 women had been assisted at the Center, among them about 70 were welcomed at Casa Abrigo (Adrião, 2019). Thus, although the country has suffered interruptions in the advances of national policies for women, Recife remained a reference in the discussions of a GSB.

In 2017, the city of Belo Horizonte also committed to establishing policies to achieve gender equity by 2030. Coutinho and Souza (2023) analyse whether the municipality of Belo Horizonte's budget planning instruments were, in fact, more sensitive to gender issues after the launch of the Municipal Gender Equity Plan (MGEP). The equity committee presented 139 actions organized into six categories: governance and planning, economic empowerment, political participation, confronting violence, health, and inclusive education. The study observed that 90% of the resources foreseen in the budget allocations defined as gender sensitive were executed between 2018 and 2022 (Coutinho; Souza, 2023). The proximity between the planned and executed spending for Belo Horizonte demonstrates the city hall's importance and commitment to budget initiatives. However, little has been disclosed about the impacts of these expenditures to assess whether they were, in fact, effective in improving women's lives.

5. Final considerations

The invisibility of the existing inequality in access to the basic rights guaranteed by the Constitution is sometimes the result of the pillars of neutrality, universality, and efficiency that guide Brazilian public administration. Thus, historically unequal groups are treated equally. The decisions of action - and also omission - of the State impact different social groups in different ways (Melo, 2020): for example, budget reductions in resources directed to public social protection policies will have direct negative effects on the poorest population, and tax exemption measures on profits and dividends favor groups with higher income, composed mainly of white people (Gomes et al., 2022). Also, according to Melo (2020), by not considering existing social inequalities, access to goods and services offered by the State becomes disproportionately distributed, differently impacting men and women and white and non-white populations, corroborating the perpetuation of socioeconomic inequality between these groups.

The lack of progress in reducing inequalities is a reality across economies worldwide, and it is also the responsibility of public agendas that lack a strong commitment to the theme (Dionísio de Andrade, 2020;

[8] https://www.tre-go.jus.br/comunicacao/noticias/2019/Dezembro/retrospectiva-da-decada-lei-de-incentivo-a-participacao-feminina-na-politica

[9] https://www1.folha.uol.com.br/poder/2022/09/partidos-descumprem-cota-para-mulheres-e-negros-na-distribuicao-do-fundo-eleitoral.shtml

Piketty, 2015). At the same time, the macroeconomic structure itself acts as a limitation to a budget that is responsive to gender and race issues, elevating the State to the position of mediating agent between investors, distancing itself from the concept of a State that promotes the well-being of the population and sustainable economic development (in social and environmental aspects) and often abdicating to prioritize social spending in favor of a performance expected by the market. This biased redefinition of priorities points to an imminent risk of accentuation of inequalities and concentration of income and wealth.

It is a fact that a certain level of scientific and bureaucratic attestation is necessary for the institution of government policies. However, precisely to honor this commitment to scientific objectivity and bureaucratic impersonality, one must consider the specific realities of the country that cannot be standardized and must be understood in the context of the transversality of social structures that perpetuate inequalities, such as gender and race (Melo, 2020). This is especially relevant from the point of view of government planning and the preparation of the public budget, which must include the active participation of the population. The participatory budget serves as an important tool for guaranteeing social rights and strengthening mechanisms of equity, decentralization, efficiency, and anti-corruption (Hofbauer, 2003). In addition, it is necessary to strengthen women's political representation in parliament, ensure their active participation in budget formulation, and create institutional mechanisms to prevent this from being restricted to "soft politics"[10] topics.

Gender-sensitive budgeting is a social inclusion tool that should not be underestimated in its ability to highlight structural problems and push for the redefinition of priorities on the public agenda. Thus, if the recent re-implementation of the Women's Budget meant a step in this direction, this modest advance is still insufficient. In challenge to the recent trajectory of austerity, in which social and distributive policies compete for space within the new Sustainable Fiscal Regime (Brenck et al., 2023), the implementation of a GSB in Brazil would represent an important achievement that would undoubtedly strengthen women in the next stages of this broader political clash.

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[10] Following the North American classification, "soft policies" are those associated with care topics, such as health and sanitation, housing, education, culture and sport, etc. These are themes traditionally linked to the female social role.

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